Abolishing Elected District Councils in Vietnam:

Research Question, Data, and Descriptive Statistics

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1. Research Question

The Main Question for my project is: in 2010, did rural communes in districts whose elected council was abolished have a different number of basic infrastructure services than communes in districts that kept their council? In 2009, Vietnam tried removing the elected District People's Councils in some districts as a test, which let the province and the national government run those districts more directly. I want to know if losing the council changed how many basic services the communes in those districts had.

My X variable is *treated_district*, which is 1 if a commune is in a district that lost its council and 0 if the district kept it. My Y variable is *infrastructure_index*, which counts how many of five basic services a commune has, so it goes from 0 to 5. Since X only has two values, I am just comparing two groups: the average number of services in communes that lost their council (X = 1) and in communes that kept it (X = 0).

I think communes that lost their council will have slightly fewer services, about 0.25 fewer each, or a quarter of one service. My reason is that council members live in the district. When the district decides how to spend its money, council members can speak up for a village that needs a road fixed or wants a market. Without the council, those choices are made by officials who work for the province instead of for the people in the commune. I think those officials would care more about big projects that make them look good and less about small villages. As a result, the communes lose some of their say.

I am not very sure about this, though. Vietnam has only one political party, so these councils may not have had much power anyway, and taking them away might not change anything. It is also possible that cutting out a level of government makes things get done faster.

The authors of the study point out both sides of this. Elected councils are supposed to make officials do their jobs, but they can also be taken over by powerful local people who block projects (Malesky et al., 2014, Introduction section). Because of all this, I picked a small number, and I would not be surprised if the real difference turned out to be close to zero.

To decide what counts as small or big, I think about it in terms of whole services. A difference under 0.1 services would be small, since that is less than a tenth of one service per commune. A difference of 0.5 services or more would be big, because that is like half of all communes losing a whole service. My guess of 0.25 is in the middle, so I would call it a medium-small effect.

2. Data and Measures

The data come from the commune part of the Vietnam Household Living Standards Survey (VHLSS). It is the same survey Malesky et al. (2014) use in their *American Political Science Review* article. The project file, *analysis.csv*, has rural communes from 58 provinces in Vietnam in two survey years, 2008 and 2010. It does not include the five Central Highlands provinces or any communes missing the household-density number (POLS 209, 2026). Of these 58 provinces, 10 had their councils removed in some districts (Malesky et al., 2014, p. 144).

Each row in the file is one commune in one survey year. There is no way to match the same commune in 2008 and 2010, so the data are a repeated cross-section, not a panel. That means each row counts on its own, and I do not try to follow communes over time.

The file has 4,126 rows: 2,081 from 2008 and 2,045 from 2010. My question is only about 2010, so I kept the 2010 rows, which left 2,045. Then I checked for blanks in X and Y. There were none, so I did not drop any more rows. My final sample is 2,045 communes.

For X, *treated_district* is 1 if the commune's district lost its elected council in 2009 and 0 if the district kept it. This is the change my question is about. For Y, *infrastructure_index* adds up five yes/no services: a village road that can be used all year (*year_round_road*), any village road (*village_road*), public transport (*public_transport*), tap water as the main water source (*tap_water*), and a government building project (*socioeconomic_infrastructure_project*). Each one is 0 or 1, so one point on Y means one more service. I used both variables as they are and did not change their scale.

I also picked three other variables to describe the communes:

- *households_in_commune* is the number of registered households in the commune. It tells me how big each commune is.
- *distance_to_nearest_town_km* is how far the commune is from the nearest town, in kilometers. This shows how out of the way a commune is, which probably makes services harder and more expensive to build.
- *program_135_commune* is 1 if the commune is in Program 135, the government's program for very poor communes, and 0 if not. I used this instead of the poverty rate to show which communes are poor. The codebook says the 2010 poverty rate was measured after the councils were removed, so the change itself could have affected it.

The typical commune in my sample is pretty big and a little far from town. The average commune has about 2,129 households (the median is 1,966) and is about 11.7 km from the nearest town (median 8 km). About 19.5% of communes are Program 135 communes, and 13.3% are in districts that lost their council.

3. Descriptive Statistics and Distributions

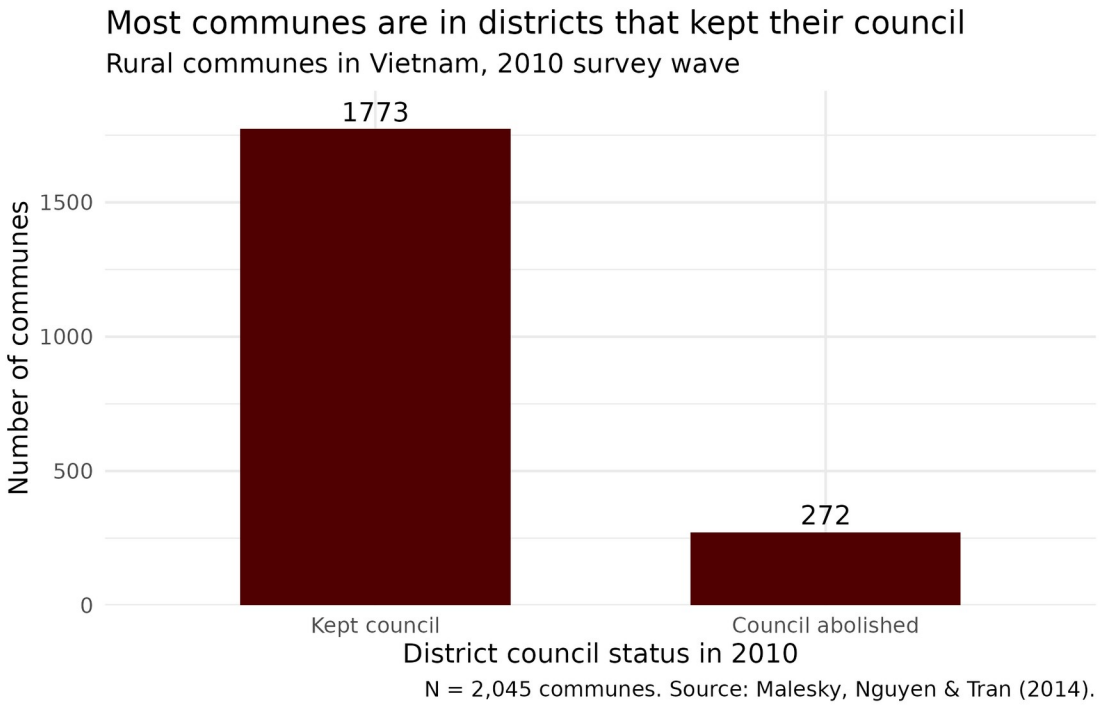


Figure 1 shows that the two groups are very different in size. Only 272 of the 2,045 communes (13.3%) are in districts that lost their council, while 1,773 are in districts that kept it. Because the group that lost its council is so small, its average is based on far fewer communes and is less exact than the other group's.

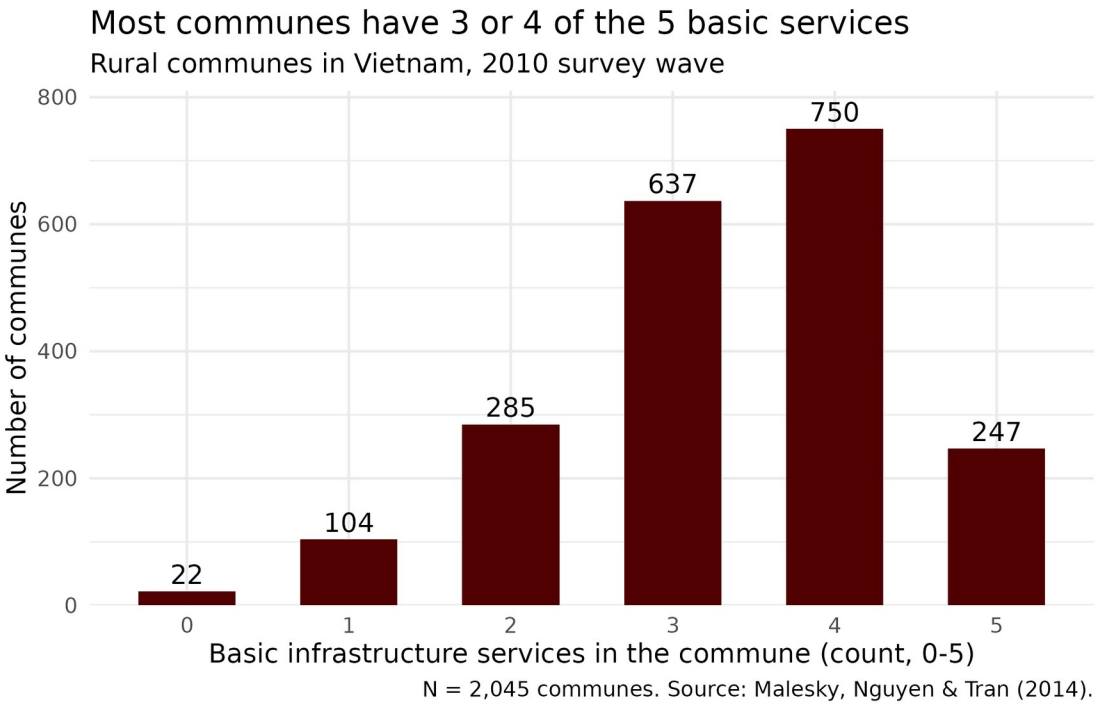


Figure 2 shows that most communes already have a good number of services. About 68% have 3 or 4 of the 5, and only about 6% have 0 or 1. The mean is 3.34, the median is 3, and the standard deviation is 1.09. Table 2 shows that the middle half of communes (P25 to P75) has 3 or 4 services. About 12% already have all 5 and cannot go any higher. If losing the council actually helped services, those communes would have no way to show it.

Table 1. Summary statistics (2,045 communes, 2010)

Variable	N	Mean	SD	% observed
In council-abolition district (X; 1 = yes, 0 = no)	2,045	0.133	0.340	100%
Basic infrastructure services (Y; count, 0-5)	2,045	3.335	1.085	100%
Households in commune (count)	2,045	2,128.800	1,457.611	100%
Distance to nearest town (km)	2,045	11.674	12.861	100%
Program 135 disadvantaged commune (1 = yes, 0 = no)	2,045	0.195	0.396	100%

Table 2. Percentiles (2,045 communes, 2010)

Variable	Min	P1	P10	P25	P50	P75	P90	P99	Max
In council-abolition district (X; 1 = yes, 0 = no)	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1
Basic infrastructure services (Y; count, 0-5)	0	0	2	3	3	4	5	5	5
Households in commune (count)	155	335.9	754.6	1,295	1,966	2,743	3,539	5,361.6	43,583
Distance to nearest town (km)	0	0	0.6	4	8	15	25	60.6	160
Program 135 disadvantaged commune (1 = yes, 0 = no)	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1

Source: Malesky, Nguyen & Tran (2014), APSR 108(1): 144-168.

Two of the other variables have a few really large values. The median commune has 1,966 households, but the biggest has 43,583, which pulls the mean up to 2,129. Distance to town follows the same pattern. The median is 8 km, but the 99th percentile is 60.6 km and the farthest commune is 160 km away. For both of these, the median gives a better picture of a normal commune than the mean.

Compared to how much Y varies, my guess of 0.25 fewer services is about 0.23 standard deviations of Y (0.25 divided by 1.09). It is also about a quarter of the gap between the 25th percentile (3 services) and the 75th percentile (4 services). That would be noticeable but not huge. However, when I compare the actual 2010 averages, the difference is even smaller than my guess and goes the other way. Communes that lost their council average 3.39 services, and the others average 3.33, a gap of +0.06 services, or about 0.06 standard deviations. By my own cutoff, that is a small difference.

Looking at just one year does not prove my guess is wrong. The districts that lost their councils were not picked at random, so they could have been different from the others even before 2009. The article deals with this by using a difference-in-differences design, which compares how services changed from 2006 to 2010 in both groups instead of looking at one year (Malesky et al., 2014, p. 144). Also, since most communes have 3 or 4 services, there is room for a drop of a quarter of a service to show up, but communes already at 5 cannot show an increase. For now, the numbers point to a small effect, which makes me think the councils may not have mattered as much for local services as I first thought. I would need the before-and-after comparison to really test it.

References

Malesky, E. J., Nguyen, C. V., & Tran, A. (2014). The impact of recentralization on public services: A difference-in-differences analysis of the abolition of elected councils in Vietnam. *American Political Science Review, 108*(1), 144–168. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055413000580

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